

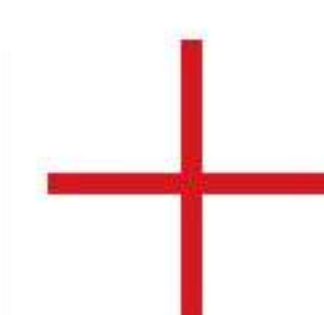


United front: Ehsan Mani recalls how Jagmohan Dalmiya led PILCOM to successfully organise the 1996 World Cup, symbolising unity and cooperation.

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visas after prolonged deliberation. It remains uncertain whether Indian journalists will be allowed to cover the tournament in Pakistan. Local reports suggest ticket sales for Pakistan's home matches have been strong, with seats for the marquee India-Pakistan clash already sold out. Until recently, doubts loomed over whether the tournament would proceed in Pakistan. But Mani remembers a time when the late Jagmohan Dalmiya led a

Pakistan-India-Sri Lanka Organising Committee (PILCOM) to organise the 1996 World Cup in the subcontinent. "We worked as a team. We spoke regularly and ensured that things went ahead smoothly. We all had a common goal: *cricket hoga*, and it will be a success for Asia. Mr Dalmiya, Mr I.S. Bindra, myself, and others regularly interacted to ensure we got the tournament in shape, Mani said. Ramiz believes the event will be crucial in changing perceptions about



THE SCHEDULE

Feb 19: Pak vs. NZ – Karachi

Feb 20: Ban vs. Ind – Dubai

Feb 21: Afg vs. SA – Karachi

Feb 22: Aus vs. Eng – Lahore

Feb 23: Pak vs. Ind – Dubai

Feb 24: Ban vs. NZ – Rawalpindi

Feb 25: Aus vs. SA – Rawalpindi

Feb 26: Afg vs. Eng – Lahore

Feb 27: Pak vs. Ban – Rawalpindi

Feb 28: Afg vs. Aus – Lahore

Mar 1: SA vs. Eng – Karachi

Mar 2: NZ vs. Ind – Dubai

Mar 4: Semifinal (A1 vs. B2) – Dubai

Mar 5: Semifinal (B1 vs. A2) – Lahore

Mar 9: Final – Lahore/Dubai

Matches to start at 2:30 PM IST.

(All squads in team previews as of February 11)

Pakistan, which enters the tournament as the defending champion.

"When you grab those centre spreads in the newspaper regularly for all the right cricketing reasons and become the centre of attraction, it not only fulfils your expectations but also allows you to dream ahead..." Ramiz said.

Mani, however, believes that frequent visits by top teams have already helped to create a positive image of Pakistan. "During my time at the PCB, from 2018 to 2021, we ensured that teams started travelling to Pakistan. Over the last few years, image-building has been done successfully, as a result of which top teams are coming in. During my time, I never heard visiting teams complain about security. They would often tell us to relax things a bit so that players could step out and enjoy themselves," Mani said, adding: "With security taken care of, teams are now comfortable travelling to the country, and hopefully, the Champions Trophy will only make things better..."

After three decades of waiting, Pakistan's fans finally have something to celebrate.